



STARTUPS



Meet the first batch of VCs
set to judge Startup
Battlefield 200 at
TechCrunch Disrupt 2025

From Dropbox to Cloudflare, Startup Battlefield alumni have redefined industries. Who will win \$100,000 and the spotlight this year?

Startup Battlefield 200 is the crown jewel of TechCrunch Disrupt — and this year's competition promises to be unforgettable. From thousands of applicants, only the top 20 will take the Stage at **Disrupt 2025** (October 27-29, San Francisco) to pitch their vision to panels of top-tier VCs in front of a live audience. Every contender is chasing game-changing impact — and we're here for the drama, the breakthroughs, and the big reveals.

We're thrilled to announce our first wave of judges who will put these startups to the test with rigorous, no-holds-barred Q&A. Their candid feedback offers a rare window into how world-class investors size up a company — what excites them, what concerns them, and what makes them want to take the next meeting.

IMAGE CREDITS:

KIMBERLY WHITE/GETTY IMAGES FOR TECHCRUNCH

Winning Startup Battlefield has launched companies like Dropbox, Mint, Vurb, and Cloudflare into the spotlight — and with a \$100,000 equity-free prize on the line, the next big name could be born on the Disrupt Stage this October.

Don't miss this high-stakes startup pitch-off on a global stage. Learn from emerging founders what it takes to deliver a winning pitch, and hear directly from the investors judging the contenders. [Register now for Regular Bird savings.](#)

First look: Meet the VCs taking the judges' seats

Here are the first five VCs ready to help crown the Startup Battlefield 2025 champion — with more top investors to come soon.

TECHCRUNCH DISRUPT

October 27-29, 2025 | San Francisco

Put your brand in front of 10,000+ tech and VC leaders across all three days of Disrupt 2025. Amplify your reach, spark real connections, and lead the innovation charge. Secure your exhibit space before your competitor does.

[Book Your Table >](#)

Most Popular



- HR giant Workday says hackers stole personal data in recent breach
- How your solar rooftop became a national security issue
- A comprehensive list of 2025 tech layoffs
- Co-founder of Elon Musk's xAI departs the company
- Google CEO adds a new calendar feature at Stripe co-founder's request
- NASA has sparked a race to develop the data pipeline to Mars
- Why I finally left Spotify



Philip Clark, Investor, Thrive Capital

[Philip Clark](#) is an investor at [Thrive Capital](#), where he has partnered with leading software and hardware companies that are engineering breakthrough advancements in AI and robotics, including Anduril, Cursor, Neuralink, Physical Intelligence, and Wiz. He previously invested at Bridgewater. Philip graduated from Stanford with degrees in Computer Science and Management Science and Engineering. He continues to advise the Hoover Institution on various topics in emerging technologies.



Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital, Elad Gil — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$600+ before prices rise.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

REGISTER NOW

Madison Faulkner, Partner, NEA

[Madison Faulkner](#) is a partner at [NEA](#) investing in early-stage data, infrastructure, developer tools, data science, and AI, and she also leads the data and AI platform internally for improved

investment decision-making. Across her investing career, she has worked with startups including World Labs, Factory, Ceramic, Metabase, Datafold, Delphina, Mindtrip, Fixify, and others. Prior to investing, Madison was head of data science and machine learning at a growth startup, Thrasio, head of data science at Greycroft, and led a data science team at Facebook focused on the ad auction and deep learning with FAIR. Madison received a BS in Engineering from Stanford and grew up in Colorado performing in rodeos.

Leslie Feinzaig, Founder & General Partner, Graham & Walker VC

[Leslie Feinzaig](#) is the founder and general partner at [Graham & Walker](#), an early-stage venture fund backing extraordinary founders and ideas that break the mold, whose mission is to change the face of public markets by backing a new guard of founders and CEOs. Prior to launching the fund, Ms. Feinzaig was a 2x startup exec with eight- and 10-figure exits who started her career under the tutelage of HBS Professor Clayton Christensen, author of the seminal theory of disruptive innovation.

Ilya Kirnos, Founding Partner & CTO, SignalFire

[Ilya Kirnos](#) is the co-founder, managing partner, and CTO of ~\$3 billion AUM early-stage venture firm [SignalFire](#). He leads the development of SignalFire's in-house Beacon AI data platform, which he's been building for a decade with the firm's team of AI PhDs, engineers, and data scientists. Beacon tracks more than 660 million employees and 80 million companies to guide the fund's investing by surfacing high-quality founders and fast-growing companies, and assists its portfolio companies with recruiting and customer acquisition. As an investor, Ilya focuses on backing seed to Series B companies in enterprise infrastructure and developer tools. He supports highly technical startups in SignalFire's portfolio, including Horizon3 (autonomous pen-testing), OneSignal (notification infrastructure), and PlanetScale (scalable databases).

Doug Pepper, Partner, ICONIQ

[Doug Pepper](#) is a general partner at ICONIQ Growth. He joined [ICONIQ Growth](#) in 2019. Doug has helped lead ICONIQ Growth’s investments in Airtable, Guild Education, Reify, and others. Prior to joining ICONIQ Growth, Doug was a managing director at Shasta Ventures, a premier early-stage venture capital firm. Previously, he was a general partner at InterWest Partners for 15 years, where he was the first investor in Marketo and served on its board of directors for 10 years. He began his career working at Goldman Sachs and Amazon.com.

Register now to join the pitch-off action in October

[TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#) marks 20 years as the launchpad for tech innovation. The startup landscape has evolved, but Disrupt remains the place where industry leaders shape the future. From invaluable sessions and game-changing connections to Startup Battlefield, it all happens here this October. [Lock in your ticket at low rates now.](#)

We’re always looking to evolve, and by providing some insight into your perspective and feedback into TechCrunch and our coverage and events, you can help us! Fill out [this survey](#) to let us know how we’re doing and get the chance to win a prize in return!

Topics: [Disrupt 2025](#) [Fundraising](#) [Startup Battlefield 200](#)

[Startups](#) [TC](#) [TC Event Promo](#) [TechCrunch Disrupt](#)

[TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#) [Venture](#)

[f](#) [X](#) [in](#) [🍷](#) [✉](#) [🔗](#)

TechCrunch Events

[View Bio](#) >

———— KEEP READING ————



IMAGE CREDITS: [FLICKR](#)

STARTUPS



The wait is almost over: The 2025 Startup Battlefield 200 list drops August 27

Isabelle Johannessen — 9:22 AM PDT · August 18, 2025

Set your alarms. Bookmark this page. Refresh like your future depends on it.

After reviewing thousands of groundbreaking applications from around the globe, TechCrunch is just days away from announcing the 2025 Startup Battlefield 200 — our handpicked cohort of the most promising early-stage startups set to take the stage at [TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#) this October 27-29.

The 2025 Startup Battlefield 200 list will go live, right here, on Wednesday, August 27, at 9:00 a.m. PT.

Whether you applied, referred a standout founder, or just want to see who made the cut, this is the moment you've been waiting for. Your name. Your rival. Your next investment. They might all be on this list.

Advertisement

Newsletters

[See More ↗](#)

Subscribe for the industry's biggest tech news

This October marks 20 years that [TechCrunch Disrupt](#) has been shaping the startup world — and we’re pulling out all the stops. For two decades, the biggest names in tech, venture capital, and startups have taken our stage to share their visions and make history. Game-changers like Dropbox, Cloudflare, Fitbit, and Discord got their start in [Startup Battlefield](#) — and this is where the next generation of breakout companies will be born.

Want to see these rising stars pitch live? Hear from top-tier founders and investors? Network with the people shaping the future of tech? [Grab your ticket to Disrupt 2025](#), happening October 27-29 in San Francisco.

Last year’s winner, [Salva Health](#), topped a competitive field of startups with its development of a portable device to detect breast cancer early, especially in rural populations that lack access to mammograms and other diagnostic tools. You can relive their victory below, [listen to our Equity podcast interview with CEO Valentina Agudelo](#), or [get a detailed rundown of their journey here](#).



Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital, Elad Gil — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They’re here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don’t miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — **grab your ticket now and save up to \$600+ before prices rise.**

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

REGISTER NOW

TechCrunch Daily News

Every weekday and Sunday, you can get the best of TechCrunch’s coverage.

Startups Weekly

Startups are the core of TechCrunch, so get our best coverage delivered weekly.

TechCrunch Week in Review

Get the best of our coverage, delivered to your inbox every Saturday.

TechCrunch Mobility

TechCrunch Mobility is your destination for transportation news and insight.

No newsletters selected.

Email address

Subscribe

By submitting your email, you agree to our [Terms](#) and [Privacy Notice](#).

Advertisement

Announcing the winner of Startup Battlefield 200 | Tech...



Salva was far from alone. Out of the cohort of 200 trailblazing startups, TechCrunch editorial selected the [2024 Top 20 finalists](#) who wowed the crowd with their disruptive innovations, live demos, and perfected pitches. Runner-up [geCKo Materials turned heads with its compelling story](#) about how years of research led to a breakthrough innovation in adhesive materials that is disrupting the Velcro industry one impossibly sticky situation at a time.

This year's Startup Battlefield 200 Top 20 finalists will be revealed on Day 1 of Disrupt 2025 (Monday, October 27). You don't want to miss the chance to see these founders battle it out live onstage for the \$100,000 prize and Disrupt Cup. Your incumbent will be there. Your competitors have registered. Don't get left behind — [get your tickets to Disrupt 2025](#).

Mark your calendars and set your alarms — the 2025 Startup Battlefield 200 list drops right here on Wednesday, August 27, at 9:00 a.m. PT. Be the first to see which exceptional startups made the cut.

Startup Battlefield is proudly presented by Google Cloud, our premier sponsor.

TECHCRUNCH STARTUP BATTLEFIELD 200

OCT 27-29
SAN FRANCISCO

Powered by Google Cloud

We're always looking to evolve, and by providing some insight into your perspective and feedback into TechCrunch and our coverage and events, you can help us! Fill out [this survey](#) to let us know how we're doing and get the chance to win a prize in return!

Topics: [Gecko Materials](#) [Salva Health](#) [Startup Battlefield](#)

[Startups](#) [TC](#) [TechCrunch Disrupt](#)

[TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#)



Isabelle Johannessen

Startup Battlefield Program Manager

Isabelle leads Startup Battlefield, TechCrunch's iconic launchpad and competition for the world's most promising early-stage startups....

[View Bio](#) >

KEEP READING

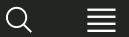
STARTUPS





AI crawler Firecrawl raises \$14.5M, is still looking to hire agents as employees

Latest
Startups
Venture
Apple
Security
AI
Apps



Events
Podcasts
Newsletters

He was in a coffee meeting with Nexus Venture Partner's Abhishek Sharma at the Blue Bottle in San Francisco's South Park (a favorite VC haunt). While describing the future of the company, he was gesturing so animatedly that his chair tipped over.

"I actually fell out of my chair. And Abhishek, as a great Investor does, caught the chair and me as I was falling," Pepper described with a laugh. That felt like a symbol for how the founder/investor relationship is supposed to work. "I think that was a clear signal that he was the right partner."

On Tuesday, Firecrawl announced a Series A led by Nexus with participation from Shopify CEO Tobias Lütke and existing investor Y Combinator.

Firecrawl offers a popular open-source web crawler for developers and AI agents, with a commercially supported version available through API. It's used by 350,000 developers, has nearly [50,000 stars](#) on GitHub and its notable customers include Shopify, Replit, and Zapier as well as "some of the largest hedge funds in the world," Pepper told TechCrunch. And, he says, the company is already profitable.

It's more than banking.

It's reading the break from one dashboard.

Mercury is a financial technology company, not a bank. Banking services provided through Choice Financial Group, Column N.A., and Evolve Bank & Trust; Members FDIC.

Latest in Startups

The startup also just released an API that supports search and will soon add support for natural language prompts, as co-founder and CTO Nicolas Silberstein Camara noted.

Peffer, who co-founded Firecrawl in 2022 with Camara and CMO Eric Ciarla, said gaining Lütke as an investor was “the best kind of validation.”



Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital, Elad Gil — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They’re here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don’t miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$600+ before prices rise.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

REGISTER NOW

They landed him through a gutsy email after discovering the Shopify founder had signed up to try their product through their self-service portal.

“We saw his email come in,” Peffer said. The Firecrawl crew immediately emailed him to welcome him as a customer, but got no response. Two months later, some Shopify folks contacted Firecrawl for an enterprise contract. So Peffer took his shot and emailed Lütke again, mentioning they’d love for him to participate in their upcoming round.

This time, Lütke responded with compliments about their product. He was in.

While AI web crawlers have [a somewhat dubious reputation these days](#), mostly due to bad actors [that ignore robot.txt files](#), they are also a necessary part of the burgeoning AI world. AI trains on the web, [agents need to access web pages to perform their duties](#), and enterprises need personalized crawlers to consume their own websites for training and operations.

See More

ENTERPRISE



CPG startup Keychain snags \$30M to build in India, grow in the U.S.

Jagmeet Singh

- 52 minutes ago

STARTUPS



AI crawler Firecrawl raises \$14.5M, is still looking to hire agents as employees

Julie Bort - 4 hours ago

TECHCRUNCH DISRUPT 2025



The wait is almost over: The 2025 Startup Battlefield 200 list drops August 27

Isabelle Johannessen

- 22 hours ago

The Firecrawl founders also hope to help address the frustrating parts of their industry. They are working on tools to help website owners, publishers, and other content creators “get paid when AI uses their content. We think this is the way it should be,” Peffer said.

While there have been lots of efforts around this idea from big names like [Adobe and Getty](#) as well as startups [like Bria](#), [Calliope Networks](#), and others, Peffer feels that Firecrawl has an edge because it’s already working with those who are scraping data.

“We already have one side of the marketplace,” he said. “What we want to do is just connect that side of the marketplace to the website owners, the publishers.”

Interestingly, Firecrawl also went viral a few months ago for reasons that have little to do with their open source tool. They had posted an [ad to the YC job board looking to hire an AI agent as an employee for a \\$15,000 salary](#) – perhaps the first job ad for an agent employee, ever.

That job search didn’t yield an agent worth hiring, so Firecrawled upped the budget to up [\\$1 million to hire several agents and the developers who built them, and tried again](#). Applicants flooded in, Peffer said, but the company hasn’t yet hired any. The founders realized that evaluating and managing wanna-be agent employees is a job in itself. So now they are looking for an AI chief of staff.

Firecrawl’s Peffer will [be on stage at Disrupt in October](#) to discuss all that he’s learned in a session that covers the pros and cons of hiring AI agents as early employees.

Topics: [AI](#) [AI agents](#) [Startups](#) [TC](#) [Webcrawler](#)

[f](#) [X](#) [in](#) [👤](#) [✉](#) [🔗](#)



Julie Bort

Venture Editor | [X](#)

Julie Bort is the Startups/Venture Desk editor for TechCrunch.

...



IMAGE CREDITS: KEYCHAIN

ENTERPRISE



CPG startup Keychain snags \$30M to build in India, grow in the U.S.

Jagmeet Singh — 7:00 AM PDT · August 19, 2025

[Keychain](#), a U.S. startup that [helps consumer brands find manufacturing partners](#), has raised \$30 million in fresh funding as it looks to scale its India-based development team to drive growth in North America.

While headquartered in New York, Keychain operates as a distributed company with its core engineering and product development centered in India. The startup is doubling down on this model with the new funding, aiming to grow its engineering, product design, and analytics teams in Gurugram from 35 to 70 in the coming months, and to around 100 within a year. This India-based team already represents half of Keychain's 70-person global headcount, with about 20

employees in New York and the remainder in Austin, handling partnerships, go-to-market, and sales.

The strategy is deliberate. Despite only serving Western markets, Keychain has built its primary development operations in Gurugram — which is the country’s second-largest tech hub after Bengaluru — to develop its consumer packaged goods (CPG) platform for clients in North America. The software platform already helps eight of the top 10 retailers, including 7-Eleven and Whole Foods, and seven of the top CPG brands, such as General Mills, connect with potentially suitable manufacturers, according to the startup. So why India?

“It’s the talent, depth, availability, and the speed with which you can access talent of that depth and availability [in India],” said Oisin Hanrahan, co-founder and CEO of Keychain, in an interview.

Hanrahan co-founded Keychain in 2023 with Umang Dua — his co-founder at Handy, a home services software startup later acquired by Angi — and Jordan Weitz. Dua, who is originally from New Delhi, has been a “natural advantage” in building Keychain’s core teams in Gurugram, Hanrahan said.



KEYCHAIN CO-FOUNDERS JORDAN WEITZ, OISIN HANRAHAN, AND UMANG DUA
(LEFT TO RIGHT)

IMAGE CREDITS:KEYCHAIN

Both Hanrahan and Dua spent time structuring Keychain’s teams across India and the U.S., ultimately choosing India as the company’s engineering hub. The decision was shaped by their experience at Handy and Angi, where they found it

MERCURY

It’s more than
a wire.



It’s paying your crew
without hidden fees.

Mercury is a financial technology company,
not a bank. Banking services provided through
Choice Financial Group, Column N.A.,
and Evolve Bank & Trust; Members FDIC.

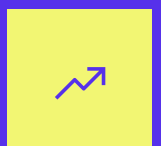
TECH DISRUPT

October 27-29, 2025 | San Francisco

Put your brand in front of 10,000+ tech and VC leaders across all three days of Disrupt 2025. Amplify your reach, spark real connections, and lead the innovation charge. Secure your exhibit space before your competitor does.

[Book Your Table >](#)

Most Popular



- HR giant Workday says hackers stole personal data in recent breach
- How your solar rooftop became a national security issue

challenging to build a “sustainable, enduring” engineering team in the U.S.

“We’ve thought about engineering as: how do we build a core, sustainable engineering organization that can get to scale reasonably quickly, that has endurance, that’s got deep talent pools, and AI exposure that can take on real, important challenges, that’s commercially minded? And we looked at where we had those teams before, when we were at Handy and Angi, and obviously, India is just an amazing location and really checks a lot of those boxes,” Hanrahan told TechCrunch.



Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital, Elad Gil — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They’re here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don’t miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$600+ before prices rise.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

REGISTER NOW

- A comprehensive list of 2025 tech layoffs
- Co-founder of Elon Musk’s xAI departs the company
- Google CEO adds a new calendar feature at Stripe co-founder’s request
- NASA has sparked a race to develop the data pipeline to Mars
- Why I finally left Spotify

Several U.S. startups, [especially those developing SaaS solutions](#), base their engineering and product teams in cities like Bengaluru, Gurugram, and Noida. In recent months, the country has also seen a [wave of multinational companies establishing offshore hubs](#), often referred to as global capability centers. But unlike most of these firms — which also target Indian consumers even as many say [India is harder to sell into](#) — Keychain stands apart. It more closely resembles companies like the UK’s [Deliveroo](#) and Southeast Asia’s [Gojek](#) and [Grab](#) — all of which tap into India’s tech talent for product development and R&D without having a market presence in the country.

“India’s position as a global technology hub has made it a compelling destination for product development, even for startups that have no direct business in the country,” said Neha Singh, co-founder of the Bengaluru-based private

market intelligence platform Tracxn, in an interview with TechCrunch.

India's time zone also allows teams to work beyond U.S. hours, enabling near-continuous development cycles, Singh added.

KeychainOS as the next big thing coming from Indian talent

Keychain plans to use its India team not only to improve its current platform — launched in February 2024 and used by over 20,000 brands and retailers to find manufacturing partners — but also to build new AI-powered software that helps manufacturers manage their product cycles more efficiently and with better oversight.

Called KeychainOS, the software will have four modules, with the first one already available. This module helps manufacturers comply with their food safety requirements, using AI to take quantitative data and convert it into a qualitative report that can be shared with auditors. The software can also pull data using natural language when an auditor requests a specific insight, Hanrahan told TechCrunch.

The other three modules of the software will focus on purchasing and procurement, inventory, and production planning, the executive noted.

The OS offering will compete with traditional ERP systems like Oracle, QAD, and Plex, which require add-ons like TraceGains and Redzone to be usable for manufacturers, the startup said.

In addition to its KeychainOS for manufacturers, Keychain has embedded AI into its search and discovery layer to help retailers quickly find relevant third-party manufacturers for their products.

KEYCHAIN'S SEARCH AND DISCOVERY LAYER WITH AN AI INTEGRATION

IMAGE CREDITS:KEYCHAIN

Keychain already helps brands and retailers find third-party manufacturers in food, beverage, supplements, health, and beauty categories and is looking to expand its platform to pet and household products later this year.

Currently, the startup serves businesses in the U.S. and Canada and is [aiming to enter Europe](#) later this year.

While the startup offers its software free to brands and retailers, manufacturers pay to access the platform and get discovered. KeychainOS provides them with another reason to engage.

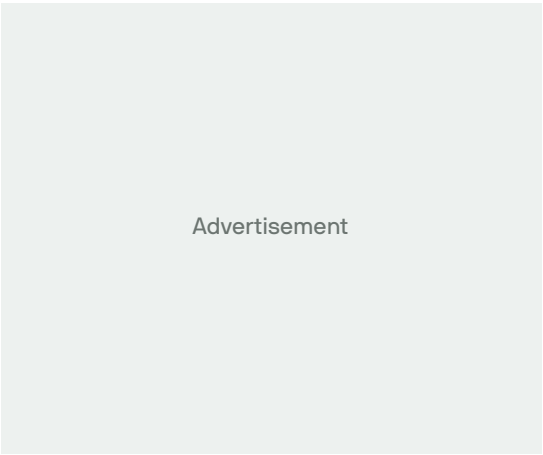
Keychain already has over 30,000 manufacturers on its platform, with “hundreds and hundreds” paying to use it. These customers pay anywhere from \$10,000 to over \$100,000, Hanrahan said, adding that the startup earns around \$20,000 per manufacturer annually on average.

Keychain's Series B round was led by Wellington Management and existing investor BoxGroup, alongside other existing investors. With this funding, the startup has raised \$68 million in total. Of that, Hanrahan told TechCrunch that the startup still has over \$50 million in the bank.

The startup had a post-money valuation of \$260 million in its last round of \$15 million in November 2024. Hanrahan did not disclose the current valuation but said it was a “good step up.”

Topics: [Enterprise](#) [India](#) [Keychain](#) [KeychainOS](#) [North America](#)

[Startups](#) [United States](#)



Advertisement

- [f](#)
- [X](#)
- [in](#)
- [👤](#)
- [✉](#)
- [🔗](#)

Jagmeet Singh

Reporter | [X](#) [🦋](#) [@](#) [in](#)

Jagmeet covers startups, tech policy-related updates, and all other major tech-centric developments from India for TechCrunch. He...

View Bio >

Loading the next article



- [X](#)
- [in](#)
- [f](#)
- [📷](#)
- [▶](#)
- [m](#)
- [@](#)
- [🦋](#)

- TechCrunch
- Staff
- Contact Us
- Advertise
- Crunchboard
- Jobs
- Site Map
- Terms of Service
- Privacy Policy
- RSS Terms of Use
- Neuralink
- Google Chrome
- StubHub
- Claude
- GPT-5
- Tech Layoffs
- ChatGPT